of millions of refugees throughout Europe needed to be resettled, and this was on top of the rehabilitation of the continent from the terrible destruction caused during the war. The years immediately following the war were used by the powers to reshape and rehabilitate the world. It took five years for the United Nations to establish the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR) in 1950, which defined the term *refugees* under the UN Refugee Convention, ratified in 1951. According to this definition, *a refugee is a person who is outside his/her country of nationality; has a well-founded fear of persecution because of his/her race, religion, nationality, membership in a particular social group or political opinion; and is unable or unwilling to avail himself/herself of the protection of that country, or to return there, for fear of persecution.*

The UNHCR's mission, from its inception onward, was to resolve the problem of refugees *by resettling them*, and it has indeed succeeded in this mission. To this day, the agency continues to address and solve the problems of people around the world who have become refugees as a result of various wars.

The struggle to establish the State of Israel, the War of Independence that broke out immediately upon the declaration of the establishment of the state, and the responsibility that Israel took upon itself with regard to the survivors of the Holocaust and Jewish refugees are, I believe, comparable in magnitude to the horrors of World War II itself. This is the only explanation I can offer to the question of why the founding fathers of Israel and each successive Israeli government failed to understand the obvious: that the unfortunate 1949 vote at the United Nations (a year before the establishment of the UNHCR) to establish the United Nations Relief and Works Agency (UNRWA) was a seed that was planted by the Arab and Muslim countries, using their automatic majority in the UN, with the inention of perpetuating the Palestinian refugee problem. The seed sprouted and became a plant, a tree, and then a jungle that may now be impossible to contend with.

In my estimation, Ben-Gurion's priorities in those days were, first, the establishment of the state, its institutions and an orderly government, in the midst of armed struggle and war; and second, mass immigration to Israel, both as the state's duty toward Holocaust survivors in Europe and as a way of changing the country's demographic balance. Ben-Gurion saw the resolution of the conflict and the achievement of peace as a vision for the